AKC CHAMPION **Stonewalls Misty Mountain Maggie**

(and how I became an Owner/Handler for Conformation Competition)

By Barry R. Kogut



photo by Barry R. Kogut

My wife Kathy and I love dogs and have had dogs essentially through our entire married life.

We started with a beagle (Molly) and then with a growing family, we welcomed over time two golden retrievers (Ginger and Sunny), a Newfoundland/Golden mix (Bear) and a flat coated retriever (Bella). When Bella passed in the fall of 2019, we thought that we should take advantage of our empty nest and travel as we were both retired. However, as they say in Italian, "una casa non é complete senza un cane" and so early in the following year, we began to look for another dog.

When I was leaving for college, my Dad got a Brittany (Lancer) that he used to hunt pheasants and grouse. Lancer was affectionate and eager to please and Kathy was ready for a smaller dog that did not shed as badly as our retrievers.

We live in Upstate New York near Syracuse and when we could not locate a local breeder, we looked south. We found Stonewall Kennels and breeder James Harrison in Harrisonburg, Virginia and selected from a 4-pup litter born on June 18, 2020, a female that had a striking white mask on her face that looked like an elongated heart. We named her Stonewalls Misty Mountain Maggie and the adventure began.

The first year was tough. Maggie was a handful and clearly an alpha dog. There were those razor baby teeth that on more than one occasion drew blood or made a hole in a shirt.

During those early walks, Maggie was constantly finding something in the grass and deciding to sample it. The worst was when she found a discarded COVID paper mask. Despite our pleading to drop it, she ate it. Thanks to a quick call to our vet, we learned the secret of hydrogen peroxide to induce vomiting and the crisis passed.

Fast forward a year later to a grooming date with Nancy Morabito, a representative of the Hudson Valley Brittany Club, our closest regional Brittany club. Nancy was an artist with her grooming, and she was impressed with Maggie's look.

After Nancy reviewed Maggie's pedigree, she asked me if I realized that Maggie had a grandfather, GCHP CH Rainbow Splash's Ruggedly Handsome, who was a two-time National Specialty Best of Breed winner. I said that I did but had not fully appreciated what that meant. Nancy said that I should show Maggie. I thought, "Why not? How hard could this be?" I would soon find out.

There follow the highlights of what I learned on my conformation competition journey that culminated in Maggie's earning her AKC champion title on July 1, 2023.

Conformation competition is unique. After paying the registration fee, a rookie handler is entitled to enter the ring alongside paid professionals and owner/handlers who have been competing with their dogs for most of their adult life. What I knew about conformation competition came mainly from watching the Westminster Dog Show on TV and viewing the movie, Best in Show. It was clear early on that I had to leave my ego at the door as I was going to get schooled as I made my way. You do not know what you do not know.



Maggie receives her final point to earn her conformation championship title.

You use a special leash. The key is to get comfortable with this thin kangaroo leather leash adorned with bright colorful beads and keep it tight around the dog's neck and up on her head. After a 4-day competition, I often had blisters on my left hand from holding that leash as I made my way around the ring.

It can be chaos as you await entry into the ring. Here is an example of the chatter as I waited in line. "Kathy, please stop trying to brush Maggie's feathers. She looks fine." "I'm sorry. Maggie did not mean to sniff your dog." "Maggie, what are you eating? Drop it." "Head up Maggie." "OK Maggie let's go. Game time."

This is an athletic event. It is not like running the 100-yard dash, but I had to be ready to move when Maggie opened up on her initial gait around the ring. Also, the tension that I felt prior to being called into the ring reminded me of the times that I was on the swim block in high school getting ready for the starting gun.

Maggie and I needed to work to get on the same page. It did not help to have those conformation classes at 8 PM. Maggie was tired after a long day and so was I. She often checked out early. I was told that I had to make the practice more fun. Huh? But then somehow, it just came together. We had to mature as a team.

Bad weather at outdoor events can be challenging. It is no fun to gait around the ring in the rain, but you do it. Temperatures are often in the 40s for those early ring times in late September at the Wine Country Circuit in Romulus, New York. And during the 4-day competition in Bainbridge, New York last year where Maggie received her final champion points, it was almost unbearably hot and humid with the smell of the Canadian wildfires in the air.

I was fortunate to have a mentor. I needed more focused guidance to compete against the more experienced competitors in the ring and I got it from my friend Mary Walker, who has a male Brittany, Lincoln, who is two days younger than Maggie and also an AKC champion. Her rules for me – show the profile, keep the leash tight, minimize the feeding and position correctly on the down and back.

The handler needs to become invisible. The judge's focus needs to be on the dog and if the handler is unduly fussing with the leash, stacking the dog or getting the dog under control, the qualities of the dog can get lost in the confusion. To minimize this, I found that it helped to visualize the two-minute routine before entering the ring.

After getting her AKC championship, Maggie entered a Brittany specialty competition sponsored by the Hudson Valley Brittany Club in late July 2023 and won a Best of Opposite. So, Maggie is now on the road to becoming a Grand Champion (and maybe a visit to Westminster) with a much wiser owner/handler.

The adventure continues . . .



photo by: Mary Walker. Maggie won Best of Opposite at a Hudson Valley Brittany Club specialty competition, July 2023.



Barry Kogut is a retired attorney who enjoys writing, cycling and working with his wife Kathy in their large vegetable garden located on a farm property in Fabius, New York where Maggie loves to run. Maggie enjoys her conformation competition with Barry and her rally, scent work and obedience classes and competition with Kathy.